

China: Trade resilient, but hard to sustain growth alone

Extel - 2026

Global Fixed Income Research Survey

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- *June trade beat expectations, but signals stabilization, not reflation.*
- *Exports resilient but concentrated; imports production-led, not demand-led.*
- *Net trade should support 2Q GDP and June IP, but stronger imports cap boost.*
- *We see 2Q growth slowing to 4.7%oya, with firmer IP but weak absorption.*
- *Tariffs and Hormuz energy risks make trade a less reliable 2H cushion.*

June trade data was stronger-than-expected and more balanced than in April–May and at the start of the year. Exports rose 5.6%*m/m sa* to 27.0%*oya* (JPM: 20.4%; market consensus: 19%), imports rose for a seventh straight month by 2.1%*m/m sa* to 36.0%*oya* (JPM: 29.7%; market consensus: 26.1%), and the surplus widened to US\$125.6bn. Export gains broadened across destinations and products, led by high-tech goods, autos and selected consumer goods, while mobile phones and computers stayed soft. Import gains were concentrated in high-tech inputs and selected commodities, pointing more to production and supply-chain needs than to a broad recovery in final demand. The big picture is resilient goods trade and continued support to end-2Q activity, but with production-linked trade flows still running ahead of domestic absorption.

Exports rose 5.6%*m/m sa*, confirming resilience but also a clear sectoral tilt. Shipments increased to the EU (+5.9%*m/m sa*), EM Asia (+5.8%, including +8.2% to Taiwan) and the US (+0.9%), with additional gains in Latin America and Africa. By product, the rebound was led by low-end consumer goods (+5.8%) and high-tech exports (+2.1%, the eighth straight monthly gain), with integrated circuits up 3.0% and autos up 13.1% (69.6%*oya*). This shows strength in both traditional competitive exports and higher-end manufacturing, but industrial rebalancing remains uneven: electronics, semiconductors, autos and selected consumer goods are firm, while mobile phones (-5.5%) and automatic data processing equipment (-4.1%) turned soft, likely reflecting recent memory price changes.

Imports rose 2.1%*m/m sa*, but the signal is still production-led rather than demand-led. By origin, gains were led by Australia (+20.4%*m/m sa*), the EU (+5.8%) and the US (+4.2%), while imports from EM Asia fell 1.1%, including a 3.1% decline from ASEAN. This points to some sourcing diversification, but not a broad regional supply-chain upswing. By product, high-tech imports rose 2.3%, consistent with AI/electronics input demand, while commodities were mixed: coal, natural gas, soybeans and copper volumes rose, refined products rebounded, but crude oil and steel products fell. The import mix suggests supply-chain rebuilding and selective commodity restocking, with limited evidence of a broad demand rebound.

Emerging Markets Asia, Economic and Policy Research

Feng Zhu

(852) 2800 1745

feng.zhu@jpmorgan.com

Tingting Ge

(852) 2800-0143

tingting.ge@jpmorgan.com

Jiayi Li

(852) 2800-5229

jiayi.c.li@jpmorgan.com

Tongfang Yuan

(852) 2800-0085

tongfang.yuan@jpmorgan.com

JPMorgan Chase Bank, N.A., Hong Kong Branch

Resilient trade, rising external fault lines

External risks are becoming more clustered. Trade frictions with the US, Europe and ASEAN are likely to intensify around EVs, batteries, solar, mature-node semiconductors, green products and possible transshipment. Tariffs, local-content rules and anti-subsidy actions may not trigger an immediate export rollover, but they raise the cost of relying on external absorption. The AI cycle remains supportive, but concentration risk is rising: a setback in AI capex, tighter technology controls or weaker volume demand could hit the main source of recent export resilience.

Hormuz risk is the second key external shock. US-Iran tensions have re-escalated around the Strait of Hormuz: after US strikes resumed on July 7, Trump notified Congress on July 10 under the War Powers framework, starting a new 60-day window for military operations without congressional authorization. Renewed attacks on commercial shipping near Omani waters and a proposed 20% “protection fee” on cargo through the strait have raised freight, insurance and energy-price risks. The strait is not closed, but the risk of disruption remains high. For China, the risks are higher crude, LNG and shipping costs, and weaker global goods demand if energy prices stay elevated.

We expect trade to cushion the slowdown, but it cannot deliver reflation on its own. June trade data indicate that activity should be less weak than in April–May, yet the growth impulse still comes mainly from external demand, AI/electronics, trade rerouting and policy-supported production. A durable recovery still requires faster fiscal execution and stronger demand-side policy support.

For the 2Q GDP and June activity data to be released tomorrow, trade points to production stabilization, not a demand-led rebound. Stronger exports and a wider surplus suggest net trade should remain positive for 2Q growth and support June IP, especially in electronics, autos, electrical machinery and capital goods. But the seventh straight month of import gains should cap the net-trade boost, while the imports mix still does not point to stronger final demand. We expect 2Q real GDP growth to slow to 3.3%/q saar, or 4.7%oya, from 6.7%/q saar in 1Q. June activity should show firmer IP after the April–May soft patch, but weak absorption through retail sales, investment and housing. The risk is two-sided: stronger export-linked production and net trade could lift growth, while stronger imports, weak domestic demand and soft pricing could limit the payoff. In short, trade supports stabilization, not reflation.

Merchandise trade

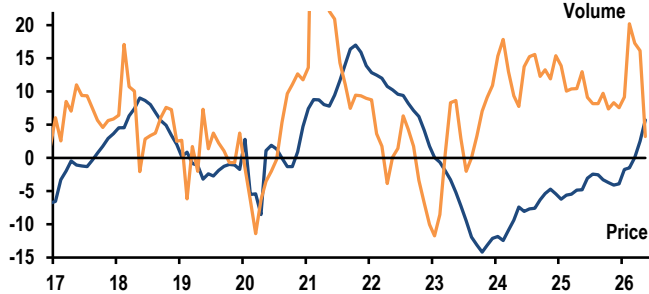
US\$ billion and percent change

	2025	Mar-26	Apr-26	May-26	Jun-26
Exports					
\$ billion	3770.5	321.0	359.2	376.8	412.4
%oya	5.4	2.5	14.0	19.4	27.0
%m/m, sa		-19.0	7.1	3.5	5.6
Imports					
\$ billion	2589.2	270.9	274.5	271.3	286.8
%oya	0.2	28.3	25.2	27.4	36.0
%m/m, sa		4.3	2.6	3.4	2.1
Trade balance					
\$ billion	1181.3	50.2	84.7	105.4	125.6

Source: Customs Statistics, J.P. Morgan

Exports volume vs. price (US\$)

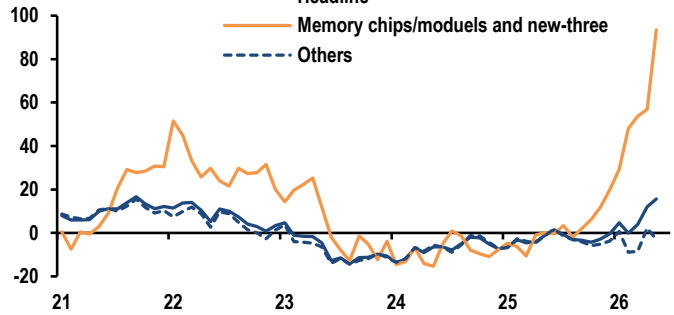
%oya, 3mma



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

Export price breakdown (in US\$ terms)

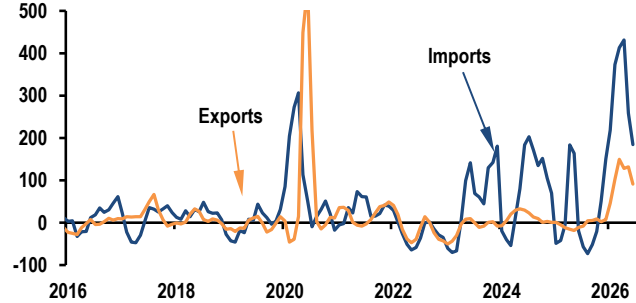
%oya



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

Automatic data processing machines & unit

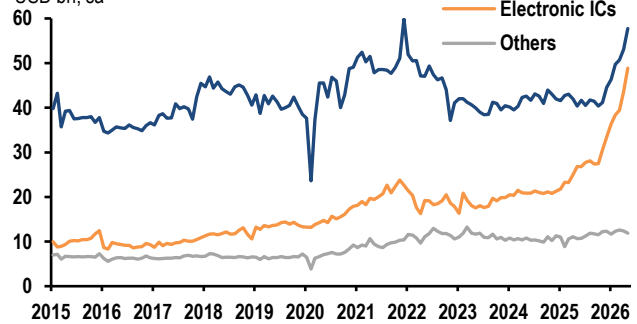
%3m/3m saar



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

China's high-tech exports

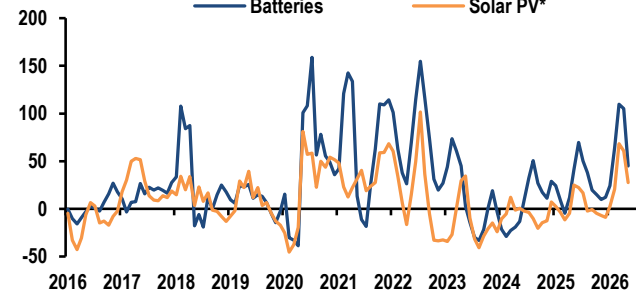
USD bn, sa



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

China battery and solar PV exports

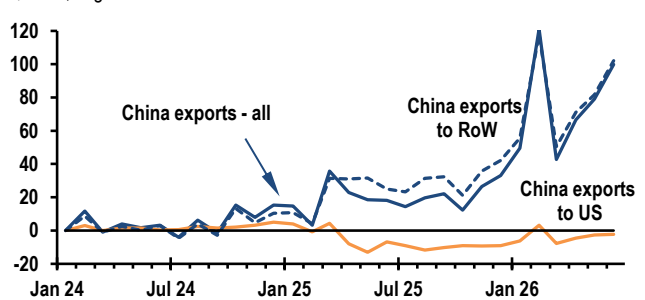
%3m/3m saar



Source: CEIC, J.P. Morgan. *Estimates at HS4-digit level

China exports to US and RoW

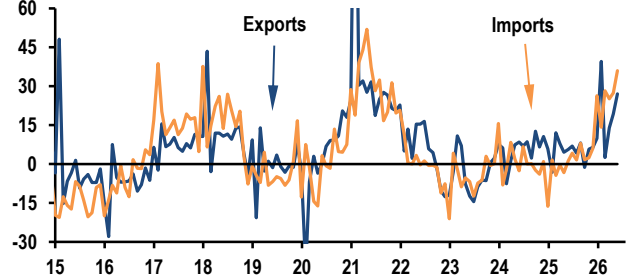
\$bn sa, chg from Jan 2024 level



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

China merchandise trade growth

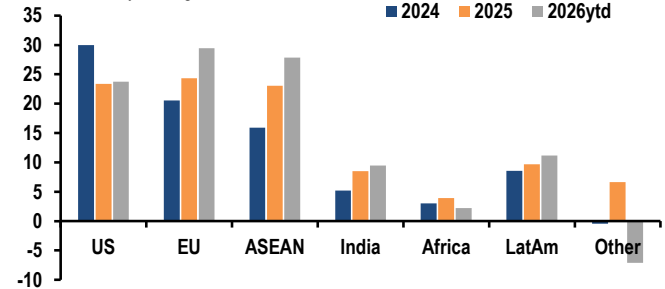
%oya



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

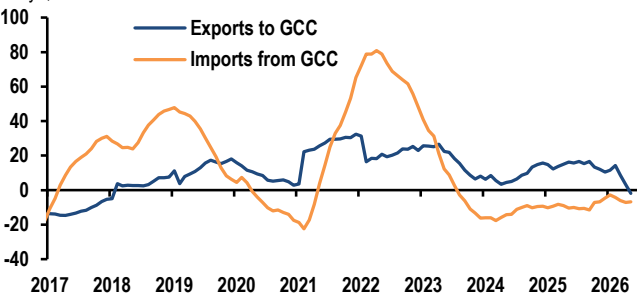
China trade surplus by partner

US\$bn, monthly average



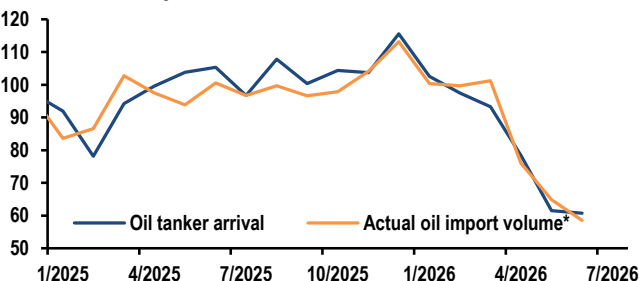
Source: NBS, J.P. Morgan

China's trade with GCC - growth rate
%oya, 12mma



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

China's oil imports
Index, Jan-Feb 26 avg = 100



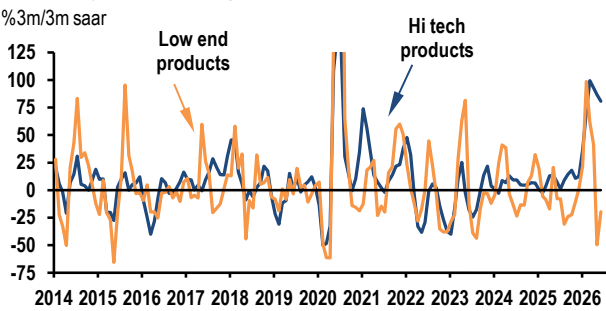
Source: IMF, Haver, China Customs, J.P. Morgan. * Includes both crude and refined oil

China exports to US vs. US imports from China
US\$bn



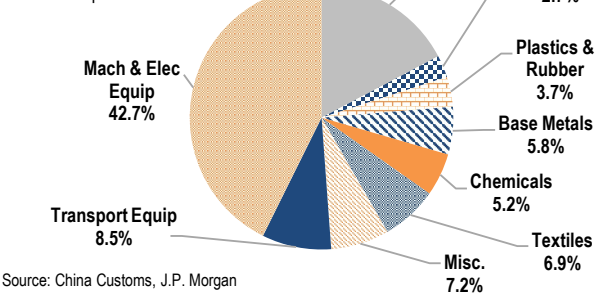
Source: China Customs, Census Bureau, J.P. Morgan

China: Major export categories



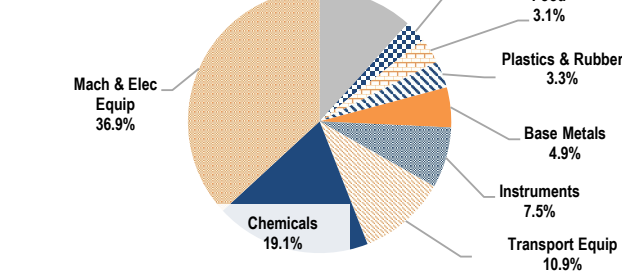
Source: China Customs; J. P. Morgan

China exports to EU by product (2025)
% of total exports to EU



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

China imports from EU by product
% of total imports from EU (2025)



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

Merchandise exports breakdown

Percent change

		2025	Mar-26	Apr-26	May-26	Jun-26
EU	%oya	8.5	8.6	13.4	7.6	18.5
	%m/m, sa		-14.3	4.5	-1.2	5.9
US	%oya	-19.8	-26.5	11.3	35.4	13.9
	%m/m, sa		-24.7	9.6	5.3	0.9
Japan	%oya	3.6	3.3	4.0	10.9	6.9
	%m/m, sa		-4.8	-1.0	6.1	-1.6
EM Asia	%oya	10.5	11.4	17.7	27.9	36.6
	%m/m, sa		-10.4	5.2	7.4	5.8
Russia	%oya	-10.5	20.6	25.7	35.8	38.0
	%m/m, sa		-9.6	2.1	7.6	-1.6
Africa	%oya	25.7	3.1	17.3	18.6	28.0
	%m/m, sa		-38.5	6.6	4.4	4.5
LatAm	%oya	7.4	-3.7	13.7	6.1	28.4
	%m/m, sa		-19.1	12.9	-6.5	11.9
Main export product categories						
Low-end consumer goods						
	%oya	-3.8	-30.4	-1.8	-2.8	5.6
	%m/m, sa		-39.7	19.7	0.0	5.8
Mechanical and electrical products						
	%oya	8.2	11.2	20.3	27.4	34.2
	%m/m, sa		-11.0	5.9	5.1	4.2
Hi-tech products						
	%oya	7.3	31.4	39.2	50.9	52.2
	%m/m, sa		3.4	4.7	8.0	2.1

Source: China Customs; J.P. Morgan

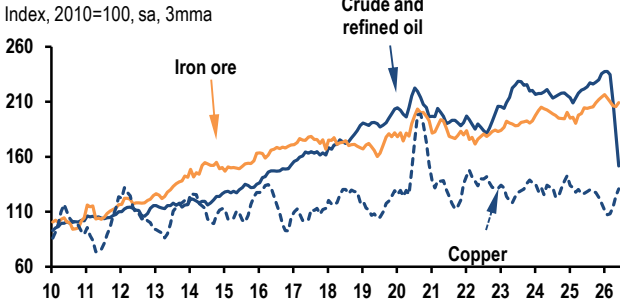
Merchandise imports by country

Percent change

		2025	Mar 26	Apr 26	May 26	Jun 26
EU	%oya	-0.4	8.5	14.5	-1.3	9.2
	%m/m, sa		0.1	1.2	-0.1	5.8
US	%oya	-14.9	1.0	9.0	20.4	25.9
	%m/m, sa		8.1	13.9	2.7	4.2
Japan	%oya	5.5	35.2	21.0	29.2	33.9
	%m/m, sa		5.1	1.0	3.3	2.5
EM Asia	%oya	1.4	25.2	34.6	38.0	43.9
	%m/m, sa		6.2	6.6	2.8	-1.1
Brazil	%oya	4.5	39.0	38.1	15.5	32.5
	%m/m, sa		-9.4	8.0	4.8	4.2
Australia	%oya	-1.7	87.6	31.5	20.5	65.8
	%m/m, sa		18.8	-8.1	-4.4	20.4

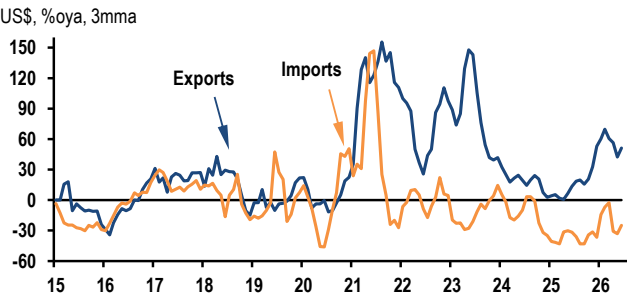
Source: China Customs; J.P. Morgan

China commodity import volume



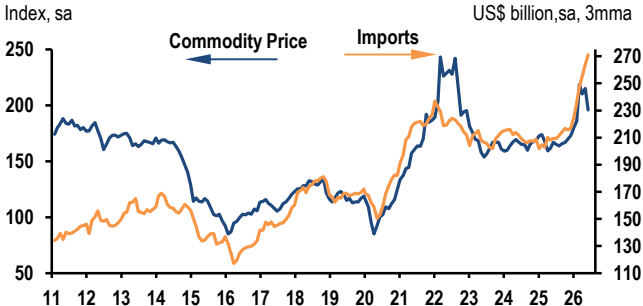
Source: General Administration of Customs, J.P. Morgan

China automobile trade



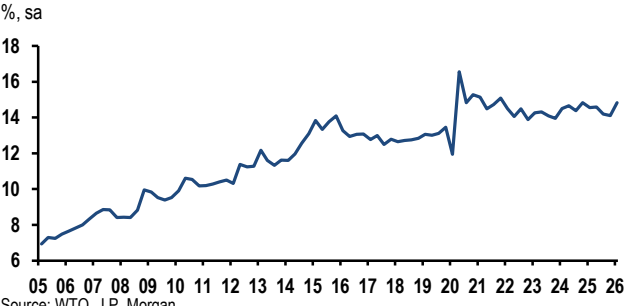
Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

China imports



Source: China Customs, IMF, J.P. Morgan

China's share in global exports



Source: WTO, J.P. Morgan

Major commodity imports (volume)

percent change

	2025	Mar-26	Apr-26	May-26	Jun-26
Crude Petroleum Oil					
%oya	4.6	-2.8	-20.0	-29.0	-41.3
%m/m, sa		0.5	-30.1	-3.8	-6.3
%m/m, nsa		4.0	-23.0	-14.0	-11.5
Refined Petroleum Products					
%oya	-12.9	19.3	-49.3	-58.1	-48.6
%m/m, sa		-24.0	-52.5	-19.8	30.7
%m/m, nsa		-23.8	-50.3	-28.0	33.2
Natural Gas	-3.0				
%oya		-10.7	-12.9	0.0	3.6
%m/m, sa		-0.4	-0.5	7.5	6.4
%m/m, nsa		-4.2	2.9	20.0	8.1
Soybean					
%oya	6.5	14.9	39.5	-15.3	10.5
%m/m, sa		-13.3	24.1	4.3	12.8
%m/m, nsa		-32.8	110.9	39.0	14.9
Iron Ore					
%oya	1.8	11.5	0.7	-0.4	6.4
%m/m, sa		0.7	-0.7	-0.8	6.7
%m/m, nsa		7.3	-0.8	-5.9	15.3
Copper					
%oya	-6.2	-10.6	2.3	3.6	4.0
%m/m, sa		9.7	11.1	5.4	0.2
%m/m, nsa		31.3	7.1	-1.0	7.3
Aluminum					
%oya	4.8	5.9	-2.7	-14.3	
%m/m, sa		1.8	-3.1	-9.4	
%m/m, nsa		24.1	0.0	-16.7	
Coal					
%oya	-9.6	0.9	-12.6	-7.7	29.5
%m/m, sa		3.7	-15.2	9.8	19.5
%m/m, nsa		26.2	-15.3	0.6	28.6
Steel Products					
%oya	-11.4	2.0	-9.6	-6.1	-6.2
%m/m, sa		17.2	-5.9	-0.6	-1.0
%m/m, nsa		37.8	-7.8	-4.1	-2.2
Mechanical & electrical products (value)					
%oya	5.0	25.9	33.5	38.2	47.5
%m/m, sa		4.0	6.7	6.5	2.3
%m/m, nsa		37.0	4.9	0.3	10.0
Hi-tech products (value)					
%oya	9.0	31.5	41.9	46.8	57.8
%m/m, sa		5.7	8.2	6.4	2.3
%m/m, nsa		41.3	4.5	0.7	10.4

Source: Customs statistics, J.P.Morgan

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Feng Zhu (852) 2800 1745
feng.zhu@jpmorgan.com
JPMorgan Chase Bank, N.A., Hong Kong Branch
Tingting Ge (852) 2800-0143
tingting.ge@jpmorgan.com

Jiayi Li (852) 2800-5229
jiayi.c.li@jpmorgan.com
Tongfang Yuan (852) 2800-0085
tongfang.yuan@jpmorgan.com

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